



Volume III | Issue I April 2016

PAHAL

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EDITORIAL

It's been almost 8 years since Disha was established and with each batch of students, the idea around which it revolves has evolved. Pahal has been a medium of viewing it. With this issue, we intend to inspect how far we have come, the current standing of Disha, and what might be in store for us.

Perspectives shared by Himanshu Badhani and Abhijeet Petkar, the veterans of this organization, give an idea about Disha in its infancy, and the path it has taken from there. The reports give a window into the current state of the programs. The continuous evolution of Disha so far is evident, but what is not as evident is the direction it is leading towards.

We at Pahal would like to be a part of this endeavour of ensuring Disha's progress is directed appropriately. We intend to do so by improving our vision of the bigger picture, while still scrutinizing at smaller scales.

Danish Kaur, Rahul Iyer and Reema Jamal

NEW in this issue

The Kids' Say! - where we collect inputs from the students under different programs.

Perspectives - a section where anyone is free to contribute works intended to ignite discussions of social relevance.

LAMAN VASTI ABHYASIKA

Shekhar Jadhav and Reema Jamal

From finding a classroom to getting electricity to managing 50 plus excited kids, Laman Vasti has come a long way in dealing with its daily challenges. The past year has been relatively smoother in terms of conducting regular classes. We have even been able to conduct a variety of productive sessions. Summer of 2015 was the first time we continued classes in the Abhyasika. This was made possible by the few volunteers who stayed back and helped. Summer classes ensured that we wouldn't have to start from step one again in the beginning of the fall semester.

Even though there was a disappointing turnout for the first Disha orientation arranged for the 2015 batch, the second meeting did get a healthy amount of participation. Empowered with a new set of volunteers, Laman Vasti began regular classes in August. We set the schedule for volunteers and distributed subjects i.e Math, Marathi and English across five days of the week. Despite recurring problems regarding the classroom space and electricity, we were able to conduct regular classes for the most part of the semester. This, of course, was made possible by our committed group of

volunteers.

Disha had a significant representation in Karavaan 2015. We put up a stall where we sold the art and craft pieces made by our kids. We managed to raise a decent amount of funds for Disha both from the sale and other generous donations from the Karavaan crowd. Laman Vasti was represented in Karavaan by Payal, a 10 year old girl with a passion for dance only limited by her father's strong disapproval. Payal had a great time participating in Karavaan dance competition and we were happy to boost her confidence. It was fulfilling for us to be able to convince her that her dreams are valid, and to pave the way to the stage for her.

For the rest of the fall semester we were able to maintain a steady schedule. We also tried out worksheets for the students to fill up which gave us a better idea about their understanding. Going into the spring semester we had hoped to revamp the batch system and focus on the content being taught to maintain consistency. But this was challenged by the fact that our regular pool of students started dwindling. We faced quite a few drop outs, and also new faces started appearing. This was accompanied by space and

electricity issues that come up now and then. Despite these challenges we have been happy to notice improvements in a few of our students. A couple of our special batch students, i.e. the students we give special attention to owing to their faster grasp of concepts, have become more confident in basic mathematical operations, and have also been able to tackle logical problems. We try to pose such problems in a context familiar to them. For example, talking about the local market where they go to sell vegetables helps them understand cost and profit better. Working in Laman Vasti for the past two years have made us realise the complex layers of the problem that we are trying to tackle. What our students go back home to is a big factor in their overall development. We have seen the community's response to our programme change over the years. Even though that is mostly for the better we still have a long way to go in terms of convincing them of their child's need for quality education. Laman Vasti Abhyasika doesn't hope to churn out engineers or doctors, all that we hope for are that the one hour they spend with us gives them a peak of a world where quality learning empowers minds to become great human beings.

The Laman Vasti Kids' say!

During one of the Abhyasikas, we went to the vasties and chatted with the kids there. Here is what we found out:

Kavita, 2nd class, knows all her mathematical operators, although she still struggles with division. She likes maths and loves painting and crafting. She would love to learn English. Her ambition is to be a teacher.

Suraj, 1st class, says: 'I really like Shekhar Sir. Because of him I know my ABCDs and 123s perfectly now!'

Anjali, Jr Kg, said she loves coming to class and likes everything that is taught. When asked to, she recited the alphabet without a single mistake!

SOMESHWARWADI ABHYASIKA

Ameya Pore

This time last year, all gears were up and expectations from each of us quite high as we were elected to be new co-ordinators. We were limited by our inexperience but steered by our determination. Our first constraint was the lack of volunteers during the summer. We ended up teaching them through games which asked them to use some simple mathematical skills. On the upside, a lot of them had fun. However,



Photo credits: Anurag Singh

most sessions ended in chaos as there were fewer volunteers to maintain order. At some point, we even had to keep the abhyasikas closed for a while. This 'volunteer depression' hits us every summer, although I hope the coming summer will be an exception.

As the semester started, freshers arrived and got quite settled to do such tenacious activities. Quite a lot of exuberant first years had signed up, but very few survived till the end. Regular classes could now start, and we were very delighted by the kids' progress. During our mid-sems in late September, there was a drop in the regularity of volunteers, but classes were still held fairly well. Post mid-sems, we planned a syllabus in an organized fashion. Things that happened randomly before were now concise and we noticed a graceful overall development. Remarkably, the improvement in mathematics was quite admirable. We started teaching fraction and decimals to a fifth grade student (not a big deal for modern teaching systems, but it is still worth mentioning). One of our pupils also cracked the Maharash-

tra state scholarship examination, a great achievement that made us all proud. In mid-October, Karavaan fever took over our campus. We organised various competitions like leaf painting, finger painting, ribbon making and the best one was selected and presented in the Disha stall at Karavaan.

Towards the end of fall sem, we also started maintaining individual performance of kids, so that at the start of every class we could continue from where we had left before. Here, we started noticing a drastic change in the mindset of parents. Private tuition classes are preferable to them over our abhyasikas. So, in spite of us conducting regular classes, the attendance of the students coming to Abhyasikas started decreasing. This made it impossible to keep track of performance evaluation as we planned.

Winter Breaks began for us as well as for the Abhyasikas. Soon, at the beginning of this spring semester we implemented the idea of starting a library system wherein books were lent to students on a weekly ba-

sis. We wanted them to undertake responsibility as part of this, so we conducted a meeting and started assigning departments. Craft department consisted of creative minded people, Management department for managing the volunteers on daily basis, Test/worksheet department for regularly conducting tests, Publicity department were some of them. Till midsem, most of these departments ran quite pleasantly. But then after mid-sems, very few departments happen to be active now. It was predominantly because most of the senior volunteers were involved in pulling off Vigyan Mela.

It was a very illuminating experience, planning different schemes to measure and ensure progress, and seeing those schemes play out, whether successfully or otherwise. However, there is a continuous evolution both in the volunteering groups and the students, and we are pleased with all signs of progress. It has been and will be an enriching experience, and we are extremely glad to be part of it.

The Someshwarwadi Kids' say!

Akanksha, 5th class, says: "This is better than school because we come here to learn and play at the same time." On being asked a way in which Abhyasikas can be improved, she commented about the need for cleanliness in the classroom. When asked what her ambition is, she said she wants to become a police officer.

Kaveri, 3rd class, says: "I learnt fractions from Lokesh Sir, which I hadn't learnt in school before." When asked what her ambition is, she said she wants to become a doctor.

Suhani, 3rd class, says: "I get bored at home in the evenings, so I come here to spend quality time." Like Kaveri, she wants to become a doctor.

Aditya, 4th class, wants to become a police officer. On being asked why he wants to become a police officer, he replied with a determined expression that he wants to catch thieves.

Everyone nodded in unison when asked if their marks in school improved after they started coming to the Abhyasika.

MINDSPARK

Aboli Ektare

After the last semester, Mindspark classes were conducted during December vacation as well. The students were given extra worksheets on Mathematics, Aptitude skills and Marathi. As spring semester resumed, the classes resumed, now being held on Tuesdays, Saturdays and Sundays. Tuesday classes are taken by Akshata Meshram (2nd year BS-MS), Saturday Classes by Manasi Gangan (Bio PhD) and Sunday class-

es by Sourabh Patil (1st year BS-MS) and Dnyanesh Dubal (Bio PhD). We taught English on Wednesdays, Marathi on Saturdays and Science and History on Sundays. In English, they are now done with word types and moved on to sentence formation. In Marathi, their writing skills and vocabulary are being worked upon to enable them to express their thoughts in limited words in limited time. In Science, they are shown

science-based videos followed by discussions about the content of the video to see how much they learnt. In history, their school syllabus for the year is covered.

We also conducted a test for them in order to see how much they have understood. We meet their parents so as to discuss their results and the solutions to any problems they face.

The Mindspark Kids' say!

A popular opinion amongst Mindspark attending students was that they had started to question every other tradition that is commonly followed and try to find some logical basis to it. They have stopped believing in some superstitions completely, such as stepping on a fallen lemon will bring you bad luck. This is a major step in rational inquiry and building a scientific temperament.

Muskan said that as they have lived with such thoughts all their lives, it is impossible for elders to accept that those are superstitions and they should not be followed.

Vishvakarma said that he has learnt to respect girls and has understood that they deserve to be treated equally.

SCIENCE NURTURE PROGRAM

Aniket Khairnar

This semester we tried a new approach: to teach Science, the subject we know best. We started as usual, selecting students from Municipal schools around Pune. We selected 18 students each from 3 schools. The entire program was designed for 8 Sunday afternoons from 02:00-05:00 PM from 14th Feb to 03rd Apr. We intended to give a glimpse of all the four major disciplines of Science - Physics, Chemistry, Math, Biology, while striking a balance between theoretical and experimental considerations. We planned the sessions so as to include a blend of Disha volunteers and distinguished Professors.

The program included sessions on various topics like Health and Hygiene, Basic laws of Electricity and Magnetism, Experiments with super cooled objects, interactive session on animal behavior, scientific enquiry, intriguing puzzles in mathematics, importance of renewable energy, ratio and proportions, etc. According to the students, they enjoyed all sessions but two sessions stood out most, namely the experiments with liquid Nitrogen and a visit to an NCL Lab.

Siddhartha Sohoni accompanied by few enthusiastic students from the first year showed us some innovative experiments to explain ideal gas laws using liquid nitrogen and dry ice. The demonstrations impressed the students greatly. Witnessing their amazement when Siddhartha dipped a rose in liquid nitrogen and then crushed it, and when spilt the liquid nitrogen on the floor which created a mystic fog to display Leidenfrost effect was very satisfying for all of us.

Their fascination with chemistry

grew further during our visit to Dr. Ogale's lab at NCL. These sessions were informative for both students and volunteers. Students were exposed to cutting edge research and technology in the field of renewable energy. The SEM images dazzled the students. They also got to learn about different nanostructures and their increasing usage in day to day equipments. We are very grateful to Dr. Ogale and his lab members for such a fascinating session.

The Science Nurture Program for this Semester was concluded with an address by Dr. Abhay Jere, Vice President of Persistent Solutions. He emphasized upon the growing need of innovative products and encouraged commercialization of such innovative ideas. After this very successful two month long program we are looking forward to expand by reaching out to more students with more activities in the next semester.

This semester, we saw an increase of four volunteers from the BS-MS as well as the PhD students. We continue to nurture science in young enthusiasts and the Program continues to nurture our enthusiasm.



Photo credits: Aniket Khairnar, Saurabh Kadam and Abhijeet Pendse

TALK FOR TWENTY

Talk 1 (30 August, 2015): Science and Society

Speaker: Dr. Anirban Hazra



The first Talk for Twenty of Fall 2015 saw Dr. Anirban Hazra share his views on the two-way dependence of science and society, especially the power structures. He first talked about politics in general and what considerations policymakers take into account before setting policies. He then listed five recent scientific milestones which heavily affected politics: the discovery of gunpowder, the discovery of usable electricity, Haber's process for industrial production of ammonia, the production of 'The Pill', and applications of Quantum Chemistry. With the help of this, he drove home the point that science inherently carries politics. He paved the way to a discussion of how science is currently done, whether politics has a say in this, and how it ideally should. The audience responded well, resulting in a very fruitful discussion about how we should play our part in forming the perfect balance in the interdependence.

Talk 2 (11 October, 2015): Is Gandhian Model still relevant in today's society?

Speaker: Adarsh Bhaskara Vasista



Adarsh started his talk by expanding on the principles of the Gandhian model: truth, non-violence and sarvodaya. He talked about the paradigm shift since Gandhi's time and how ideas such as capitalism, globalization, and so on prevail right now, and how tolerance is being compromised. He justified his opinion that the Gandhian model should still be considered by the society at large based on the need for it, and by giving examples of recent applications. The following Q&A managed to convince even the skeptics present that this model is definitely worthy of contemplation.

Talk 3 (9 February, 2016): The world is yours to change

Speaker: Sameer Thukral



Sameer Thukral, through this talk, advocated the application of principles of Buddhism in our everyday interactions. He insisted that when everyone improves their outlook towards the 'micro' activities in their life, only then can a 'macro' problem like country-wide corruption be tackled. He talked about how one can work towards positivity on a daily basis without losing sight of the bigger picture. His talk had an air of conviction, as the following discussion was very agreeable to the tone of the talk.

Talk 4 (10 March, 2016): Social Media and Youth - Connect or Disconnect
Speaker: Colonel Gaurav Chhiber



He began by defining social media as the means of communication amongst social beings. He then went on to demonstrate the construction of a friendly 'real-world' socially connected group (as opposed to virtual interacting groups like those over the internet) by having the audience perform interactive activities. He managed to create a relaxing and comfortable atmosphere. The intended message was that, while socializing over a virtual medium is very convenient and useful, we shouldn't lose sight of the advantages of having a healthy real social circle. His great oratory skills exemplified his point superbly.

Talk 5 (12 April, 2016): The Manifesto
Speaker: Himanshu Badhani



The talk under the banner of talk for twenty by Himanshu Badhani on the topic 'The Manifesto' was very well received. The talk in general addressed the matter that IISER students should have an opinion on the issues that is going on around them. They owe it to the society to inform them what is rationally correct and what is not. Himanshu systematically presented his argument by saying that a lot has happened concerning students in the recent past like occupy UGC movement, controversy in Indian Science congress 2015 etc but IISER students seem to stay mum on these matters. Apart from dinner table discussions there seem to be no other platform in IISER to have rational discussions on these matters and voice them as opinion of IISER student community. Many other national institutes are very active in pointing out the defects in the educational policies of the government. But the irony is that IISER students who are much more affected by these policies continue to remain silent. It appears as if someone else is fighting for our rights which is ridiculous. Are we not intellectually equipped to decide what is right and fight for our rights? All these factors made us realize that IISER badly needs a platform, a forum which can systematically debate on these issues, reach to a conclusion, if possible publicize our views through some medium and if necessary act. Out of the two hour session, three-fourth of the time was spent on discussion from the audience side. We received some very interesting inputs from people. Some opined why unnecessarily become a centre of attention by commenting on controversial matters. But as the discussion went on almost everybody agreed on that it is very essential to atleast talk about the issues in the first place. There were suggestions to make talk for twenty such a platform for discussions. There was a difference in opinion on whether the forum should discuss issues related to IISER or general social issues or both. Another matter of concern was how to publicize our take on certain matter as the opinion of IISER student community. To resolve all these questions and continue the discussion on how the structure of the forum should be, it was decided to have another meeting.

Rajath Sawant

SPREAD THE SMILE



The General Coordinator's insight by Mukta Joshi:

This year in Spread the Smile, an attempt to improve upon the quality and quantity of the science experiments and the general activities was made. Activities were systematically designed by the resource team. To plan our excursions better, the villages were visited in December by the village coordinators. We also sold Spread the Smile badges, designed by Sidharth Adithyan, which were a big hit among the IISER folk.

This time, we again visited Saaygaon, Wazeghar and Kamthadi, and also went to three new villages: Kule, Asde, and Kashig. We witnessed really good response from two of the new villages. After facing some challenges in the first week, we conducted sessions for three weeks successfully. The fourth week was not so smooth, as the students had exams in the coming week.

In terms of number of volunteers, this year was disappointing, especially after the overwhelming number we saw last year. There were less number of registrations and a lot of people backed out. I think this can be improved next year by keeping in touch with the old volunteers and proper and timely communication with the registered volunteers. I wouldn't say STS'16 was a grand success, but it definitely was an enriching experience working as a general coordinator.

Through STS, we try to build a bridge between urban and rural life by the means of science. However, it is still in its developing stages and there is a lot that can be done. It would be interesting to see where STS lands in the coming years.





A Village coordinator's views by Pankaj Bhagwat:

Lokesh and I were the coordinators for Wageghar, a small village at the foot of the Rajghad Fort. We showed the school students some simple experiments on centrifugal force, total internal reflection, Bernoulli's effect, waves and their propagation, surface tension, etc. All of the demonstrations involved the use of everyday material which the kids could find in their surroundings. We made them realize that these simple phenomena have applications at a large scale such as in communication satellites, mobile networks, hydraulic lifts, etc. We encouraged the expression of scientific attitude in these kids by showing them that science can be done at any place or time with just a bit of imagination!

It was an amazing experience of interacting with the students, exposing them to new ways of learning science and responding to the questions that arose in their curious minds. Witnessing the kids' amazement when we showed them fascinating experiments, playing cricket with them, walking through the fields and tasting delicious sugarcane sticks, and the appetizing home-made food served with great affection- all of this was indeed worth the efforts we made.

Being a village coordinator was a challenging but interesting job. I contacted strangers (volunteers from outside IISER), interacted and shared ideas with them, and spent the entire weekend with people I had met for the first time. All of this was a new experience which helped me learn and grow as a person.

First impression of STS by Aarti Kejriwal:

I'm a first year and this was my first experience as a STS volunteer. I had never stayed in a village before this. So, it was super exciting for me to visit a village as well as to be a coordinator. The villagers were so welcoming and caring. All of us (the volunteers) stayed at the Sarpanch's house over the weekend and were served delicious food. We were strangers to them until that day but they treated us like their own children. I was overwhelmed with happiness. The kids accepted us whole heartedly without knowing who we were or where we belonged. I think that STS is a really great platform to share knowledge and spread happiness.

Volunteering for STS'16 gave me immense satisfaction.



Photo credits: Siddhi Shegde and Anshul Kapoor

VIGYAN MELA

Reema Jamal

Vigyan Mela is the time when Disha brings together Someshwarwadi and Laman Vasti Abhyasika students and their communities to take part in activities that help them learn and grow. Vigyan Mela 2016 was able to do the same despite the differences between the two communities. The event usually witnesses a chaotic group of kids fighting over their chance to participate. Learning from previous experience, this year's team had decided to bring down the number of events and to ensure a healthy volunteer to student ratio for each event, which was crucial in pulling all activities off smoothly. Vigyan Mela includes events conducted at the Vasti and in IISER. The events in IISER were aimed at the older students and the ones at the Vasti for the younger students. Art and Science activities were planned for the weekend of 19th and 20th of March 2016.

The first day started off with a leaf printing session which is one of the most popular activities among the Vasti students. They were given pots of paint and leaves of different shapes and sizes and we let them go haywire on a white chart paper. The end result was a brilliant collage of colourful prints of leaves and tiny messy hands. After that, we had an origami session, during which the kids were delighted to see paper taking different shapes. The morning session at the Vasti ended with drawing competition. The science activities at IISER started at 2:00 pm with Dr. Nishikanth Subedhar's session where he actively interacted with the students and taught them about the danger of diseases spread by mosquitoes and the need to keep our environment clean. Vigyan Mela has been a platform for our students to interact with IISER faculty many times in the past. This time we invited more of IISER students to engage with them and share their scientific curiosity. In keeping with that idea, Abhishek Ojha and Vishrut Patel demonstrated the properties of non-Newtonian fluids made from cornstarch. Danish Kaur Pannu and Abhishek Choudhary demonstrated experiments based on total internal reflection and demonstrated the principles behind many optical instruments



like periscope and pinhole camera. These activities were designed such that the students could go back and replicate the experiments themselves. First day of Vigyan Mela wrapped up with the night sky watching session in the Vasti. With the help of Aakashganga volunteers, we set up two telescopes on the rooftop of a building in the Vasti. This session attracted a lot of people from the community including the elderly.



Sunday morning was packed with energy as the kids and volunteers played games of tug of war and dodge ball. After a good round of games they were taken to LHC for chemistry experiment demonstration by Mrutyunjay Nair, who fascinated the students with chemiluminescence and sugar rainbow experiments. This was followed by a documentary screening. After lunch the students were taken back to the Vasti for the rest of Sunday's activities. Clay modelling has often been a popular channel for kids to get creative and so they did with impressive models of dinosaurs, horses and people. Vigyan Mela always ends with a treat for the students and this time we had arranged for a puppet show. On a small platform in the middle of the Vasti the artists performed for the students and people of the Vasti. Dr. AA Natu joined Disha for the closing ceremony and helped us distribute the prizes.

The success of Vigyan Mela 2016 is entirely credited to the smooth communication between the volunteers and their constant commitment in facing all kinds of challenges. Resilience is one quality that is absolutely necessary for any Vigyan Mela volunteer and Team VM 16 showed a lot of it making the weekend of activities one of the best so far.



Photo credits: Anurag Singh

GYAN SETU CONTENT DEVELOPMENT

Abhijeet Pendse

"Gyan-Setu" is a volunteering program working towards capacity-building in children belonging to the remote areas of developmentally challenged states in India. This year-long activity is organized by Educational Activity Research Center (EARC) – Jnana Prabodhini – Pune. The program entails volunteer teams visiting these states to conduct science-based workshops for school children. Currently this program is being implemented in 8 states of India: Arunachal Pradesh, Assam, Jam-

mu & Kashmir, Chhattisgarh, Nagaland, Odisha, Jharkhand and Sikkim.

Disha IISER Pune helps Gyan-Setu to design content for the above mentioned workshops. In this regard, Disha Volunteers designed activities in Mathematics, Biology and Scientific Reasoning. The process involved brainstorming amongst Disha Volunteers and choosing activities suitable for the target students. This activity exposed the volunteers to a larger set of activities aimed at teach-

ing students the basics of Mathematics, Biology and Scientific Reasoning. Choosing and documenting activities involved a lot of challenges to meet the pedagogical needs, but the end result was extremely fulfilling. The volunteers strongly feel that involvement of more volunteers from different fields at IISER would not only enrich the program, but also the participating volunteers would be enriching their own knowledge and understanding of basic and hence advanced science.

A FRESH VIEWPOINT

Rajalakshmi Sawale

Disha has always been and I am sure in the coming days will be a great experience for me. I joined Disha in the beginning of my first semester. Teaching children in abhyasikas is a wonderful experience. Through Disha, I have certainly developed a new outlook towards life. In the abhyasikas, we teach for five days a week. Along with students learning from us, we learn some helpful things from them too. They are also keen and always look forward to learn. They are curious, full of ideas and hope and display their joy at learning.

Like every year, this year too, 'Spread the Smile' was organised by Disha in the months of January and February. Here we went to villages nearby Pune. We visited the local schools

and performed different activities like experiments and demonstrations, art and craft sessions, field activities, sky watching sessions among others. The idea behind this campaign is to spread the joy of education among village kids by opening a new door of learning with fun. Also, we got to experience village life, thus indeed changing our perspective towards rural life. It also helped us to develop our planning, decision making, leadership and management skills among others.

Recently, a Vigyan Mela was conducted by Disha which was undoubtedly a great success. Various competitions such as drawing, origami and sports were conducted. We held a clay modelling session which showcased the creative skills of our

budding artists. Children were also various experiments with a motive to develop a scientific attitude in them. They truly enjoyed taking part in all the activities. Through the activities, their creative skills were prominently observed. The smiles on their faces were our payoff. Their pleasant smiling faces, energetic high fives and lively, warm tones gave us a sense of content and satisfaction.

Disha has truly been one of the best experiences I have ever had. I am basically of the opinion that, every educated person has a sort of moral and social implication towards the society to spread the wealth of knowledge. Our contribution certainly brings about a positive change towards the big picture.

PERSPECTIVES

TEACH, PRAY, LOVE

Abhijeet Petkar

When I joined IISER in 2011, I remember a group of seniors called me and asked me about my interests and hobbies. When I told them about my passion to teach and to do something for the school education system in our country, they introduced me to Disha. Disha was started by a bunch of students of 2008 batch of IISER Pune with a lot of courage and motivation to bring about a change in our current education system. I spent my first two years at IISER working with these passionate seniors. Whenever I remember them I feel happy and proud of myself. They never acted like seniors to me but always motivated me like elder brothers. One of the great things about them, I would say, is the trust that they showed towards the Disha volunteers. On behalf of Disha, I want to express my gratitude towards my seniors, Kaustabh Deshpande, Pranith Simha, Vasmithra Singh, Anup Ingole, Hardik Gajera, Mihir Umrani, Gaurav Arya and all others of their batch for their

continuous support during early years of Disha.

During last five years, I have participated in each and every activity of Disha with a lot of enthusiasm and happiness. I started my journey at Disha as the co-ordinator of Laman-Vasti Abhyasika. Whenever I used to go there to teach the kids in the evening, they would rush towards me with joy and eagerness to learn something new. They never let me feel lonely. They used to take me to their home, bring sweets during Diwali, bring some stuff for me from mela etc. I loved teaching those kids. If I were asked about Laman Vasti, I would say it is a place where you can learn to maintain good community relations. Due to continuous efforts of all Disha volunteers at Laman Vasti for best quality education, it has now gained a lot of trust and respect from the community over there. After an experience of 5 years in Disha, I realised it is a very good platform for students of IISER Pune

to explore their potentials. It is a platform to understand the problems of common people and get a sense of responsibility to try to solve them. Disha is an admirable effort taken by IISER Pune students for bridging the gap between quality education and the underprivileged in our society. I think that if more of such initiatives in colleges and institutes are undertaken in our country, (in fact, some of them are actually doing it; they need to come together, collaborate and bring large scale change), we would not be far away in bridging this gap.

At last I congratulate all volunteers, different stakeholders who helped Disha in reaching the current admirable level within 5 years of span. I thank all members of IISER Pune for their valuable support and suggestions in Disha. I am awaiting to see Disha rising and reaching in each and every corner of our country. I wish good luck to Disha!



THE IDEA CALLED DISHA

Himanshu Badhani

Kaustubh often uses the word “chingari” when asked about what he thinks about Disha. The word “chingari” translates to “a spark”. For him, Disha was intended to act like a spark for its volunteers and also for the students and other people that Disha’s volunteers worked for. As I volunteered for Disha in these years, I noticed that almost everyone had their own idea of Disha, and everyone worked independently according to their ideas. And yet, Disha always looked like (and it still does look like) the most perfectly coordinated team that one could imagine!

By the time we became a part of the institute in 2011, there was already a teaching center in Janwadi that Kaustubh and Pranith started in their second year in 2009 and was run by our seniors Sarath, Krishna and others. They did not call themselves Disha back then. A few months after joining here, I saw a poster inviting volunteers to teach the kids of the workers in IISER campus and I was particularly excited by the idea of teaching kids in our campus who do not get to go to school. But the program was cancelled because the projected idea was a little costly and volunteers were not easy to find. However the need to teach those kids could not be neglected, and hence probably for the first time Kaustubh decided that this unnamed group should be a part of this institute and not just a group of “interested students”. In a few days he set up a treasury department and we put up posters around the campus asking for funds and volunteers. We came up with a slogan “Your one pizza a month and one movie a week can bring smiles on these young kids”. We were asking for an investment of money (worth one pizza for a month) and time (worth one movie a week) from the students of IISER. The construction site Abhyasika began functioning well and with the help of Sashidhara sir, we even got our own school!



In a few months Someshwarwadi Abhyasika was set up and Shruti and Anandita were made coordinators. They

faced a lot of difficulties conducting the classes mainly because of the attitude of the parents, especially the fathers, towards education and our evening tuitions. Shruti and Anandita felt that they need to address the bigger problems in that area first. They felt that there was a need for the young girls to become financially bit more self reliant. And hence they came up with the idea of self employment programs in that vasti. Kaustubh whole heartedly supported this plan even though at that time we had no more than 15 volunteers with us.

Around the same time Sharvaree suggested an outreach program to a village primary school. The idea was to attend a school in a nearby village on every Saturday with some volunteers and conduct very simple science experiments and other sessions on art and craft and literature. Sharvaree persistently executed this plan and got a lot of other volunteers involved in it. The joy of interacting with those little kids and visiting that beautiful village made this one of the most successful programs in Disha.



Abhijeet and Ruchi made Science day so popular in Lamnawasti that it is attended by the parents and the kids with equal enthusiasm. I remember Abhijeet’s idea of calling a magician to the first Science day event who would later explain the tricks to the kids. Can one think of a more novel way of combining entertainment with learning?

Chaitra met two kids in Pashan market who worked in a tea shop. People who have known the life at Sai campus would remember that shop famous for its vada pav. Chaitra decided that these kids should also be taught and she invited a few of us to help in this endeavor. This Pashan Abhyasika with two kids and four volunteers was the most difficult task that we undertook. The shop owners did not want us to take the kids away from the shop. The kids worked there from 7am to 9pm, so we had no other option but to ask for some time off for them. The

situation turned messy pretty quickly.

We however managed to conduct the classes for a semester. As the campus shifted from Sai, we had to stop the Abhyasika.

For the Pashan Abhyasika, we hardly used any of Disha's Resources; we did not need many volunteers and any money to teach just those two kids. But we called it a Disha program, because even though Disha for us was a new name then, the idea of Disha was not. Any activity that involves volunteerism for the betterment of the society, is for us, a Disha activity. These few stories that I have mentioned show how diverse our ideas and opinions were and how enterprising each of these volunteers were. This extraordinary enterprising nature of the group was possibly because we did not have one idea of Disha, we had our own individual ideas and we worked extra hard to realize those ideas.

During my volunteering in Disha I have interacted with about 60 kids and it is very unlikely that I brought a significant change in any one of their lives. But I am proud of the fact that there are three kids who learnt their alphabets from me. Their school education started from me. The amount of impact this fact had in me is immeasurable, mainly because the change it brought in me is still under progress. There was a spark (a chingari) generated when my first student wrote down the complete alphabets and started writing down words. The fire it generated remains, it continues and will be an import-

ant part of my life. I am sure this is also true for all of the volunteers of Disha who have worked with it for long enough time.

Disha is a very small part of this big world, hence impact we have on the society may not be significant. But it became a very big part of our worlds because each one of us founded our own version of Disha. This gave us a sense of ownership of an idea and that is what motivated us to work even harder. What we achieve as a volunteer is a guaranteed significant change in our perspective towards the world. We create our own chingari. So let there be room for new initiatives and new ideas. Let there be more focus on new innovative ways of solving problems, rather than forcing all of the energy to solve the problem with a pre-existing method. Let us keep Disha innocent enough. Let it remain more of an idea (or a set of ideas) rather than a fixed definition.



THE ROLE OF LITERACY IN SOCIETY

Adarsh Bhaskara Vasista

UNESCO defines literacy as 'the ability to identify, understand, interpret, create, communicate and compute, using printed and written materials associated with varying contexts. Literacy involves a continuum of learning in enabling individuals to achieve their goals, to develop their knowledge and potential, and to participate fully in their community and wider society'. The current world literacy rate is 84%. It actually excludes world citizenry aged below 18 years, which essentially makes it an adult literacy rate. If we include people below this age, the rate can be much more. It is a very remarkable number, for it shows the extent of population which is, or at least empowered to be, self dependent. Let me elaborate what I mean by 'self dependent'. 'Self-dependent' people are those who are capable of carrying out day-to-day social and economic activities without an intervention of a second

person/means. And this 'self-dependency' becomes very important in the under-developed and the developing world, or third world as it is called. Primary reason being the major chunk of population of these countries live below poverty line. So, economic self-dependency has direct impact on their living. With the existing class differences, the majority of the poor are prone to be cheated. It is well studied that as economic status of the countrymen grows, so does their literacy rate, which is quite obvious, as in this world of industrialism and globalism it is almost impossible for any person to be illiterate but economically strong. Thus the strong European powers and the United States have sufficiently large numbers for literacy rate. But, that for under developed and developing countries is quite small (even though it is increasing in the recent past). Illiteracy and sustainable economic

development goes hand-in-hand. An illiterate country will have a large mass totally cut-off from the mainstream thinking and will drown itself in the marsh of feudal order. Hence, education plays a very critical role in moulding the economic aspects of a society.

Let us also have a look at how education has influenced social order. Almost all mass upheavals in the world have had an intimate relationship with increasing level of education in society, right from the days of French revolution. French revolution, a unique attempt to overthrow autocratic monarchy, had its seeds in formed bourgeoisie in France influenced by teachings of able Frenchmen like Voltaire. People started questioning the autocratic rule and started devising new possibilities to overcome such atrocities. As and when mass education-level has increased, such ideas have been materialised in an efficient manner. We have seen this action in anti-class (caste) struggle in India too. People from oppressed class started to question repression and this attitude kept on growing and became popular in masses as their literacy level increased. So, they started trying to liberate themselves from the old cages which had imprisoned them from time immemorial. In Indian scenario, Gandhi and Ambedkar are two fighters who worked hard to mitigate the class oppression. There was quite remarkable separation in the action-plan of these two great leaders. Gandhi insisted on social self-determination of Dalits and oppressed classes and stressed on issues like temple entry, removal of untouchability etc., which would give a feel of "one-ness" to Dalits and they would come to mainstream. Ambedkar, on the other hand, laid his complete weight on economic self-determination and emphasized on political status and so on.

Both ways are equally important and are aimed at increasing social consciousness of the country. They will only work if the community as a whole is literate and able to take the burden of society on their shoulders. Otherwise such mass upheavals will crackdown and will not sustain. This question of mass-education is of

paramount value in these modern times. Due to wide spread industrialization, poor farmers are losing their land and are migrating to nearby cities in the search of employment. For him to sustain there and compete with already established class is impossible unless he possess the minimum education to earn his livelihood. This extra-ordinary migration from semi-rural and rural areas to cities is definitely a by-product of industrialization. Due to speeding up of developmental activities and for recreational purpose, people are now turning their interests towards forest areas as they contain valuable land, trees and they form perfect weekend hangouts. So, the original inhabitants of such areas, the tribes, are being pushed away from their homeland. What can they do in such situations? They will of course migrate to the urban areas and settle down in slums. Sometimes government itself provides some alternative residing area but it will be of very little help. Think of tribes living in the forests of Sahyadri hills being pushed away and being asked to settle down in some dry areas of central Maharashtra. It is literally impossible for them to adjust suddenly to changed atmosphere. And they will end up in slums doing all kinds of illicit activities like theft and bribery. So, it is only through education, making them literate and teaching them how become self-dependent can solve many of their problems and can also bring them to mainstream. It will also help them in understanding their rights and the policies of government so that they can take active part in them.

I want share something which is not directly related to the discussion, but it is interesting. If one looks at the photographs of Gandhi and Ambedkar, Bapu is a half-naked thin person wearing a dhoti and Ambedkar is physically strong man wearing a European suit. They, I think, symbolizes their thought process. Gandhi stressed more on liberating oneself by losing and thus becoming "naked" while Ambedkar advised the community to be strong and educated. It's a strange thing, isn't it!

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